STATES AS ACTORS

Despite several arguments forwarded by a number of scholars regarding the crisis of territorial state, in the age of increased global interdependence and the proliferation of the nuclear and space technologies, the state remains the primary actor in the international system. Most scholars date the birth of the state system from 1648 and the Treaty of Westphalia (1648), although some contend that the state as it existed in the seventeenth century, was nothing but the culmination of the processes that had been happening for over 500 years before the Westphalia Treaty. However, a sojourn into history would testify that the period of 200 years from about 1450 to 1650 marked the evolution of the territorial state system. The Treaty of Westphalia brought an end to the thirty years war in Europe and, by virtue of this Treaty, the rulers of Europe shook themselves off from the authority of the Church and the Roman Empire. The apparently simple but central principle of this Treaty was “the ruler of the territory would determine the religion of that territory” which had major consequences. The pretense of religious and political unity in Europe was broken and authority was dispersed among various kings and princes, and the base for the sovereign nation-states was established. From this time onwards the important elements of statehood was conceived—a people, a territory where they lived and a government with the authority to rule over the people and the territory. The government was seen as an agent of the state, which was now considered as a legal entity enjoying sovereignty.[3]

In the course of time, the state system has undergone further development and changes due to increase in the number of states, interdependence among them in all spheres, especially in the economic sector, technological development, rise of democratic institutions, growth of international law, international regimes, regional alliances, development of military warfare and weaponries. Whatever may be the situation, it can be said with certainty that states still remain as dominant actors in the international system. As Palmer and Perkins[4] assert, the state-system “may be in its sunset period, but there seems to have been little change in its basic